Contribution to Education

Jaina monasteries and temples also served as seats of learning. Education was imparted in these institutions to the people irrespective of caste and creed. The Jainas propagated their doctrines and proved to be a potential media of mass education. The Bhairavamalai we have mentioned earlier is situated near a small village called Kukkara Palli. 'Palli' is an educational centre of Jains and villages bearing the suffix of Palli are common in many places in Tamil Nadu.

The educational institutions had libraries attached to them. Several books were written by the preachers of Jainism, highlighting the important aspects of Jainism. The permission for women to enter into the order provided an impetus to the spread of education among women.

Buddhism

Buddha's original name, Siddhartha Sakya-muni Gautama, if translated into English, would mean *Gautama who belongs to the Sakya tribe and who has reached the goal of perfection.* Gautama Buddha was a contemporary of Mahavira. His father ruled the tribe of Sakya in a region near the present-day Nepal. Gautama found that he had nothing to learn from the teachers of the old religions. The religions proclaimed that the only way to salvation was through living the life of an ascetic. But despite practicing asceticism, Gautama could not arrive anywhere near the truth. And one night, as he sat under a bodhi-tree struggling with his doubt and his loneliness, a great peace descended on him. He was no longer Gautama, the sceptic, but became Buddha, the Enlightened. At last, he had succeeded in understanding the great mystery of human suffering, its causes and its cure. Asserting that both the king (passion for pleasures) and the hermit (self-mortifications) were wrong, he discovered the middle path. The middle path is based on 'an eight-fold path' of Right understanding , Right thought, Right speech, Right action, Right livelihood, Right effort, Right mindfulness, Right concentration.

Buddha taught not the glory of God but the power of love. He held the view that all men are born to an 'equality of rights'. He undertook long journeys and carried his message far and wide. Buddha preached his teachings in Prakrit. His four noble truths are as follows:

1. Life includes pain, getting old, disease, and ultimately death.
2. Suffering is caused by craving and aversion.
3. Suffering can be overcome and happiness attained.
4. True happiness and contentment are possible, if one pursues the eight-fold path.

Buddhist Literature

Buddha's teachings for a long time were transmitted through the memory of teachers and disciples. They were reduced to writing by 80 BC (BCE). and were written in the Pali language. The Pali canon *Tripitaka* has three divisions, also known as the Threefold Basket. They include *Vinaya Pitaka, Sutta Pitaka* and *Abhidhamma Pitaka.*

Vinaya Pitaka contains the rules of the order of Buddhist monks, which must be observed for achieving purity of conduct.

Sutta Pitaka lays down the principles of religion by citing discourses as evidence.

Abhidhamma Pitaka is the latest of the Tripitaka. It deals with ethics, philosophy and meta-physics. Other prominent canonical literary works in Buddhism include:

7th Std - Social Science Term III History Uni 3 EM.indd 129 9/30/2023 12:36:16 PM